The Municipal Project Brief

Reading 4 of 4: What the class is building, what is settled and what is open

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Your assignment

You play a department head, agency leader, civic representative or partner in the fictional City and County of East Detroit, Colorado, in 2030. It has 382,417 residents in twenty provisional neighborhoods, a large, unevenly developed territory, and needs in housing, water, transit, benefits, address records, schools, safety and community facilities.

Your class writes the specification (spec) for a city-county version of Estonia's digital government. There, each agency keeps its own records and shares data through a secure layer, X-tee, under agreements (see Reading 2 and the Directory). For East Detroit's departments and outside agencies, the spec sets out:

- which records they hold
- what they share, and on what terms
- who runs the exchange
- how residents are protected
- which services come first

Nothing is approved yet: no digital identity, app, procurement, vendor, cloud platform, data exchange, governance board or first service. You help establish the facts, write the spec and implementation plan, and negotiate with other agencies to carry it out.

Choose your entry

You own one entry. Find it in the **Directory of Departments and Agencies** and claim it on the **Sign-up Sheet**. The instructor plays every unclaimed entry.

Table 1. Who owns the spec

Group	Entries	Status
City-county departments	D-01 to D-15	Must take part
Outside agencies	A-01 to A-08: school district, library district, water and sewer authority, RTD, State human services and IT, Regional Housing Authority, County Court, Health and Hospital Authority	Always represented; may refuse

Group	Entries	Status
Optional outside agency	A-09: East Detroit Health System	Only if a student claims it
Resident groups	R-01 to R-03	Test the spec; always represented

Outside agencies are worth claiming: a refusal can stop a service. Departments are assigned and must take part, but can contest policy, details, budgets, feasibility, legal authority and sequence.

What to bring to the first session

- Your entry, its service problem and one specific resident case
- Records you hold that others need, and what you need from them
- Your proposed decision and the real or fictional authority behind it
- A second option and its trade-off
- At least one internal dependency and one outside organization that might accept, negotiate or refuse
- What success looks like, plus a failure or exception case

Label every fact **REAL REFERENCE** (real), **SCENARIO** (created for the course) or **OPEN** (unresolved). Never present fictional demographics, new ZIP codes, governance powers or data agreements as existing Colorado law.

What is settled and what is open

Settled for the exercise (SCENARIO)

1. East Detroit is a consolidated city-county coping with rapid growth.
2. Its residents and services are diverse. Reading 1's demographics and neighborhoods are planning assumptions open to question. They are not real Census estimates.
3. It has working city and county departments, elected leaders, a City Housing Division and an independent East Detroit Regional Housing Authority.
4. Its civic and cultural anchors are those in Reading 1: The Hangar at Space Center, the Denver Fawns, the Colorado Apex, the Denver Pilots at Aerotropolis Park, EDPAC and the East Detroit Health System.
5. Independent of the city-county: the school district, library district, water and sewer authority, RTD, the County Court, the two hospitals, the Regional Housing Authority, state and federal agencies, airport operators and other jurisdictions.

Open for the class (OPEN)

- Exact county and neighborhood boundaries
- The local charter and resident representation

- Which services come first, and how
- Water financing
- Partnerships with outside agencies
- Information handling and sharing
- Technology and procurement
- Form, delegated powers and priority rules of any shared service, including any agreement between the two housing institutions
- Funding, ownership and digital systems for the civic and cultural anchors

Ideas from earlier drafts, open for debate

Earlier drafts presented these as adopted. None was; debate, change or reject each:

- ED-Core digital identity and ED-Wallet
- “Once only” as a fixed municipal law
- Universal zero-knowledge YES/NO data APIs
- Automated housing approvals and income checks
- Automatic school enrollment triggers or seats
- RTD fare integration
- Mandatory telemetry for parks access
- A 48-hour limit for provisional GIS records
- 60-minute emergency access tokens
- Automatic historic preservation holds
- Digital voting on public art
- Digital onboarding through libraries
- Vendor procurement and cloud hosting choices
- A phased platform launch
- A specific board size and membership

They also implied 100% voucher uptake, uniform student assignment and “zero burden” outcomes, without implementation evidence.

Three stages

Stage A: Establish the basis

Find out duties, needs, assets, costs, resident cases, limits of authority, priorities and dependencies. You may challenge the city’s starting assumptions.

- Name the need or service problem your role sees.
- Identify who faces it (a resident or worker) and in which neighborhoods.

- Separate what East Detroit provides in the scenario, what another agency controls, and what is unknown.
- List the authority, money, staff, information, facilities and partners you need.

Stage B: Plan implementation

The instructor turns agreed decisions into a draft implementation spec during a shared build.

- Propose service priorities: what comes first, and why.
- State the policy decision, who decides and authorizes it, how it runs and is staffed, who pays, what must be built or bought, and what users see.
- Set the sequence, review routes, technical and data dependencies, and first working demonstrations.
- Name an alternative you considered and how you would test the result.
- Choose the governance, procurement, technology and partnership options you can justify.

Stage C: Coordinate stakeholders

Outside agencies may accept, negotiate or refuse. Refusing still counts as taking part; redesign without them.

- Identify which departments or outside organizations must take part.
- Ask for their consent or an agreement.
- If they decline, record why and revise.
- If they set conditions, log them in the decision record.
- Name who handles complaints, corrections, appeals and ending a failing arrangement.

What the class produces

- A baseline register
- Owners for each stakeholder relationship
- A map of services and who has authority over them
- Proposed charter provisions or agreements where needed
- A log of decisions and dissents
- An implementation plan
- One or more demonstrations or tests of how a service behaves

Four governance decisions

Authority. Which public body approves a shared service, adopts standards, spends public money, invites partners and stops harmful practices: an existing city-county function, a new authority, an intergovernmental agreement, a nonprofit, or a mix? Who can overrule whom?

Ownership and operations. Who controls the domain name, cloud or hosting accounts, source code, contracts, records and derived analysis? Who answers users, keeps service hours, patches systems, handles complaints and steps in if a vendor fails? Assign each separately.

Information. For each data exchange, name the sender, receiver, purpose, fields, legal or fictional authority, consent or notice, retention period, who corrects and reviews it, incident handling and how optional sharing is revoked. “Once only,” ED-Wallet, zero-knowledge APIs and automated referrals are options only.

Money and incentives. Compare general appropriations, agency contributions, user and developer fees, land-value mechanisms, grants, special districts and contract revenue. Who pays, who benefits, and what if revenue falls short?

Choose the first service

The class picks the first service on evidence and through negotiation. Candidates:

- Address corrections across new parcels
- Permits
- Emergency housing and tenant assistance
- Intake for county-administered food or cash programs
- Transit access
- Recreation access
- Connections to schools
- Library and community support
- Emergency routing
- Public art or venue services

It can be one complete transaction, several linked touchpoints or a staff-only process, if the class can justify it.

For each candidate, ask:

- Which law or simulated authority controls the decision?
- Which agency handles complaints, review and appeals?
- What if the other agency is offline, declines, or sends a wrong record?
- What test would expose a harmful design, including for a resident with no phone or a disputed address?

Negotiating with independent agencies

A strong partner agreement states:

- Scope and legal basis
- The parties

- Service levels
- Data fields and permitted uses
- Who corrects records
- Incident handling
- Payment
- Limits on data use for training or resale
- Public transparency
- Audit rights
- How either party revokes or exits
- Duties during a transition

A memorandum of understanding (MOU) can coordinate intentions. Enforceable duties need the right legal instrument. Log negotiations in the decision record.

Example: schools. The city wants to offer an enrollment referral when residents register a move. The district could agree to a secure address check, offer only fixed referral information, demand funding and manual review, or refuse. Without the district, City GIS can keep an address record but cannot make binding enrollment decisions.

Example: transit. RTD might offer a timetable or fare exchange, accept a limited pilot, or decline. The city can still publish routes or fund its own legally supported mobility program. The scenario's rail hub does not oblige RTD to link ticketing.

Questions your entry must answer

1. Which problem, residents and neighborhoods does your entry own?
2. Who delivers it now (the city-county, the state through county administration, or another public body)? Which powers sit with East Detroit, and which elsewhere?
3. Who approves policy, allocates resources, authorizes access, corrects records, hears disputes and can stop a harmful launch?
4. Which partners are indispensable, what deal comes before launch, and what if one refuses?
5. What do residents, frontline staff, reviewers and elected officials see when a case succeeds or fails?
6. How will you know it works better, and whom might it leave out?

What happens in class

You present proposals (a department can bring several) and challenge each other's assumptions. The class compares conflicting requirements and picks what to test. The instructor then uses AI, live, to build or revise a working model: a service diagram, screen, data exchange, staff work queue, cost model or agreement test. Each choice traces to its proposer. A simulated screen or workflow does not adopt its rules or funding.

The record keeps proposals, choices, dissents, what changed in testing, failures and earlier versions. Unanimity is not required: record disagreements, refusals and missing information, and test more than one path where a decision is contested.

Where to find the background

- **Reading 1: Welcome to East Detroit**: city, people, neighborhoods, anchors, six test households
- **Reading 2: How East Detroit Is Governed**: authority, Colorado law, Michigan comparisons
- **Reading 3: Housing**: the Detroit and Home Forward cases behind the two housing institutions
- **Sign-up Sheet** and **Directory of Departments and Agencies**: every entry, its duties and where to start